

March 20 selection-preparation email

Pike wrote Solis that scenario B-7 was preferred because it exceeded the savings target and allowed “the most straightforward management consolidation.” He described Benton's salary as a material component and said Wynn, Ibarra, and Keene covered continuity, travel, and automation.

Solis replied that the file should retain the variance audit and that the termination notice must state the contemporaneous reason. Voss confirmed she could distribute Benton's Northline and Oriole work but requested transition calls after notice.

No sender identified deficient performance as the selection reason. Pike approved B-7 the next day.

March 24 termination letter

Blue Cedar informed Benton that her position was eliminated in a company reduction in force, effective that day. The letter stated that the company had to reduce annualized payroll and had determined that her management responsibilities could be redistributed.

The letter said the decision was not disciplinary and did not alter her eligibility for rehire. It offered severance under the ordinary plan and identified benefits contacts. It did not mention completion rate, client confidence, credentials, availability, travel, or any refused assignment.

Benton signed only to acknowledge receipt. Her signature did not agree with the explanation or waive the pending charge.

March 25 duty-redistribution message

Voss assigned Northline to Wynn and Oriole to Ibarra. Keene received Benton's remediation-review queue and continued maintaining the automation library. Voss herself assumed Benton's monthly quality meeting.

The message asked recipients to tell clients that Benton's departure reflected organizational alignment, not quality concerns. It praised Benton's documentation and said current audit files were ready for transfer.

Wynn's Lantern transition remained scheduled through May 30. Northline and Oriole remained scheduled through June. The message records continued client and review functions, the employees assigned to them, and no replacement audit-manager position.

April 4 position-statement preparation

Outside counsel asked Blue Cedar to identify the selection rationale and source documents. Solis answered: “salary savings plus ability to absorb portfolio,” attaching the final workbook and March 20 email. Pike added that Benton’s “relative completion/availability profile” also made the choice operationally sound.

Solis noted that completion and availability did not appear in the termination letter. Pike responded that they were supporting details, not a new reason. The later EEOC position statement included both the cost explanation and the relative-profile phrase.

The exchange is retained as nonprivileged business correspondence. It records the reasons supplied during position-statement preparation without reproducing counsel's requests for legal advice.

July litigation-hold interview summary

During a custodian interview, Pike listed salary, redundant duties, completion, willingness to travel, and client confidence as reasons for choosing Benton. Asked which document recorded a client-confidence concern, he pointed to continuity scores but identified no complaint or client request.

Voss told the interviewer Benton's performance remained satisfactory and that the December travel decline was the only availability event she recalled. Finch said finance set a dollar target but did not direct which manager to choose.

The summary records salary, redundant duties, completion, willingness to travel, and client confidence in Pike's July answer. No contemporaneous client complaint is attached to the summary.

Chronological reconciliation of explanations

The February workbook began with weighted criteria. March calibration reduced Benton on continuity, availability, and uniqueness. The March 20 email emphasized salary and management consolidation. The March 24 letter stated budget savings and redistribution. The April agency preparation added relative completion and availability. The July interview added client confidence.

The table places each phrase beside its first dated communication and cited source. Budget savings and redistribution appear in the termination letter; relative completion and availability first appear in the April exchange; client confidence first appears in the July interview. The table identifies no contemporaneous client complaint supporting that final phrase.